9

SILENCED ARCHIVES AND ARCHIVED VOICES

Archival resources for a history of post-independence India

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In January 2016, the Mumbai edition of the English-language daily *The Indian Express* carried a report on a lecture by the Indian historian Ramachandra Guha.[1] It was the eleventh annual lecture organized by Godrej Archives, an institution set up in Mumbai for the collection and preservation of records relating to the Godrej group of companies. Started in 1897, Godrej is one of the most trusted Indian brands. Widely known for steel furniture, the group manufactures products ranging from capstan moorings for submarines and liquid propulsion engines for space launch vehicles to domestic padlocks and aquafeed.[2] The annual lectures of its Archives reflect a similar bias towards thematic promiscuity.[3] Guha's lecture, however, suited the institution that hosted it. The lecture was titled 'The Challenge of Contemporary History' and was delivered on the evening of 19 January at the Chhatrapati Maharaj Shivaji Vastu Sangrahalaya, the new name for what used to be the Prince of Wales Museum of Western India in Mumbai, then known as Bombay.

According to the *Indian Express* report, Guha regretted that not many historians were working on India's history since the end of British rule in 1947. This has resulted in 'major gaps in the historical understanding of post-Independence India'. There was a dearth of 'critical analytical biographies of many key figures of our modern history', especially of leaders who worked in the provinces, away from the media glare in the capital. There was no comprehensive study of caste and elections in post-Independence India – two institutions, one ancient and the other of more recent vintage, which have shaped the fortunes of the nation's recent history.

One of the odds that a historian working on modern India comes up against is the paucity of archival material. Guha spoke of Indians being 'careless and paranoid' about records, an old complaint to which I shall return shortly. For instance, a scholar has no access to the papers of a few of India's former prime ministers. The papers of Indira Gandhi are out of bounds, and one is none too sure about the sentiments of Atal Bihari Vajpayee's family about the late leader's papers. The report

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ends with a quotation from the lecture: 'The republic of India is without question the most recklessly ambitious as well as ambitiously reckless political experiment in human history. We need to be much…better informed.'

I have known Guha for several years and have admired his work – the columns he writes for English-language newspapers as much as the lucid academic tomes. I wrote an e-mail to him in June 2020 looking for details of the lecture, and he kindly directed me to a piece he had published earlier in the *Economic and Political Weekly* (*EPW*) as more pertinent to my purpose.[4] The essay was eloquent and provocative, and it did provoke a few sharp replies from well-known Indian social scientists.[5] Maybe it was a good thing that I was not a professional historian or social scientist, anxious to police disciplinary walls or pull them down. Such irresponsible freedom as I enjoy perhaps allowed me to find some of the unlit corners of Guha's piece oddly illuminating. I could have used the bland adjective 'interesting', like a surgeon taking somatic stock of a lesion showing up on an X-ray plate. In fact, Guha uses the qualifier 'interesting' in a similar way, not as a word of praise or abuse, but as one that draws attention to the singularity of a populous country that is bewilderingly diverse, an agrarian economy lumbering to one based on industry and services, a democracy that shores up degrading gender and caste hierarchies – contradictions likely to make the historian suffer a fit of what used to be fashionably labelled 'cognitive dissonance'.[6] However, my use of the word 'illumination' is unspectacular, although rooted in the lexical context of visibility. I use it in the un-Augustinian sense of a physical event that lights up something hitherto dark, albeit not always in an intended manner.

Guha's major point is that archival documents for contemporary history are far from abundant in India. The historian, by default, has to rely on the synchronic analysis of political scientists and sociologists, in addition to papers such as court records, scarce official and personal correspondence in multiple languages, periodicals, ephemera, biographies and memoirs written by participants in the events, and journalists' accounts. India is less than democratic in matters pertaining to official records. The 30-year rule applies to classified archival materials, but most of the relevant policy documents are not transferred by ministries to the National Archives of India (NAI). Guha puts such negligence down to a mix of fear and carelessness about official records. Indians either destroy records out of sheer callousness, or because they fear exposure of celebrities whose reputation serves as the claim to their successors' privilege. Further, papers that ought to be 'public' are held in 'private' custody of the families and legal heirs of public figures. Scholars are granted access to them only if their political loyalties are deemed favourable.

The odds seem to favour academic fads that discourage archival research in recent history. However, Guha has encouraging things to say for the researcher unseduced by the blandishments of the textual turn. The Nehru Memorial Museum and Library (NMML) in New Delhi, housed in the former official residence of free India's first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, has a substantial collection of records relating to the post-Independence period – materials that one may not find in the NAI or in the records of the India Office (IOR) now in the British Library. It has

microfilms of Indian periodicals in several languages – a resource less explored than one would have expected. But then follows depressing news. At least at the time Guha published his essay (2008), the NMML had closed access to papers relating to China, Kashmir and Indira Gandhi's infamous Emergency of 1975–1977 when civil rights were suspended and dissidents arrested – resources that he had looked up when working on one of his earlier books. The State Archives, or the government archives in the constituent states of the federation, are rich sources of material, as are other government organizations –the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB), land revenue offices, different wings of the Indian police. Although Guha's silence about the quality of service is typical of his patience with the staff, scholars at the State Archives face indifference to their needs from perfunctorily trained personnel and official nostrums on how 'sensitive' items should be managed. The other agencies, not mentioned in Guha's essay, are of limited use to the researcher, since only non-current records are considered archival and access to most files are restricted. Information services are less guarded than official archives. The Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics (DGCIS) in my home town Kolkata, for instance, compiles and supplies trade data. Doubts about the accuracy of economic statistics circulated by successive Indian governments have been expressed for a while now, by no less an official than a former Governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).[7] Skewed data may have something to do with ease of access – a form of tactical generosity the secret of which I am unable to fathom. The government and its departments, the RBI, Indian embassies and United Nations agencies do not have to pay for trade statistics since the DGCIS is part of the Union Ministry of Commerce and Industry. Private users have free access to principal commodity-level data of the past two years through the foreign trade data dissemination portal. They are charged a small fee for specific requests, and institutional subscriptions allow easy downloads. Indian academic institutions are offered a 60 per cent discount on the annual bulk data cost if they abide by a 'no commercial use' undertaking.[8]

Many of these sources, being of minor relevance, are missing from Guha's list, but it includes other sources of contemporary Indian history, many of them only strictly 'archival'. There are official records relating to India in foreign diplomatic missions in New Delhi, and dispatches by diplomats accessible in the national archives of their home countries. Oral history comprises yet another resource, and it is perhaps the most relevant for this essay. What Guha has to say on oral history constitutes a moment of 'illumination' in the essay for me, although possibly in a manner unrelated to the author's purpose. The contemporary historian is at an advantage over her colleagues when it comes to oral history. A biographer of a nineteenth-century worthy cannot depend on reminiscences of living people, whereas historians researching recent events and biographers of living or recently deceased personalities can. Guha adds a caveat at this point. It would be unwise of the historian to rely entirely on oral testimonies. But used judiciously with contemporary documents, oral history may be valuable in piecing together the recent past. Guha concludes that resources for a history of the evolving –and at times contradictory – Indian

republic are not as sparse as imagined, and that the materials available are worth examining in a spirit willing to disregard the prejudices and passions of the moment.

Wise and judicious selection is easier said than done. Who decides on what is wise, who judges to what extent one should depend on, say, oral sources, and who assesses the measure of 'judicious' use? These words and phrases sound odd in a context in which historians are being advised to shun 'prejudice' and unexamined animosity. More pertinently, when does the use of oral and non-formal archives conform to the disciplinary demands of history based on hard empirical evidence? I examine these problems in the rest of this essay, with particular attention to archival resources on the history of post-Independence India.

India has more archives relating to recent history than one would gather from Guha's essay. The archival materials with newspaper houses, law-courts, government surveys such as the Archaeological Survey of India and the Anthropological Survey of India, autonomous cultural bodies funded by the Union government such as the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA), the National Digital Library of India (NDLI), which is willing to host digitized archival documents of participating institutions, modern manuscript repositories, broadcasters, television companies, film archives of the government and of academies studying media, academic institutions such as the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) in Kolkata and Tata Institute of Fundamental Research (TIFR) in Mumbai, departmental collections of universities (often started with private bequests), museums with modern themes, the State Archaeological Museums, which hold research papers of recent vintage, the State Central Libraries, district libraries, voluntary institutions and corporate bodies add up to a huge mass of often unsorted documents in multiple media. This is especially the case with apex organizations such as the National Library of India (NLI) in Kolkata, which receives print documents under the depository law.

The problem is not simply of the carelessness and paranoia of Indians when it comes to records, but one of clarity about what constitutes a historical record and who judges its value and its reliability, especially when it comes to records of the recent past. Let me cite an instance from a valuable cache of records close to the years of Indian independence that I was able to acquire for the National Library shortly before my three-year tenure as Director-General ended in March 2013. The records relate to the private diaries maintained by Nirmal Kumar Bose, one of the earliest modern Indian anthropologists and a political activist who in 1947 served as Gandhi's secretary and interpreter when the latter visited the villages of Noakhali (now in Bangladesh) where Hindus were massacred in concerted mob violence in the month of October. Murder and rape in Noakhali led to reprisals against Muslims in Bihar and elsewhere, and Bose had documented many of the details surrounding the major events in his diary. The diary of 1947 had many takers and was hence published, but not the others around the period.[9] I learnt from eminent friends of the NLI that these constituted a substantial number, and that Bose's legal heirs were willing to deliver them to the custody of the NLI. I was only too happy to bring the diaries over and add the collection to the riches of modern manuscripts in the library.

My tenure at the NLI ended soon after. Meanwhile, the Online Public Access Catalogue (OPAC) was updated, and the link to the static website that directed readers to Special Collections was removed. The NLI now has a state-of-the-art OPAC, minus crucial directories to treasures for which one has to have insider's knowledge. This at least was the case in mid-September 2020 when I last inquired to find that the invaluable Bose diaries were still uncatalogued. In this, I find no difference in the way records relating to pre- and post-Independence India are treated in official archives. Neither do the disciplinary distinctions in the social sciences matter in such instances. Bose's diaries, after all, ought to have been of equal value to anyone studying anthropology, which in India owes much to Bose's pioneering studies. In this case at least it seemed that the custodians of the NLI had little knowledge of the historical value of the diaries. The Union government set up the Gandhi Heritage Sites Panel in 2006 to identify sites associated with M.K. Gandhi. The Panel was chaired by Gopalkrishna Gandhi, former Governor of West Bengal, and had among its members Ramachandra Guha.[10] The number of sites recommended came to 39 in addition to 2000 places visited by the leader. The Gandhi Heritage Sites Mission started work in 2013. But as late as 2017, Virat Kothari, the energetic young head of the IT division of the marvellous Gandhi Heritage Portal, had no inkling of the Bose diaries at the NLI when I met him at the UNESCO House in New Delhi at an NDLI workshop.[11] Neither did he seem to think that others in charge of the collections in his institution had better information on the matter. Yet the portal is as close to being textually meticulous, visually exhaustive and technically advanced as any such enterprise in the world. One can freely access at least four printed books on Gandhi authored by Bose.[12] More interestingly, the other, less spectacular, website on Gandhi run by Bombay Sarvodaya Mandal, Gandhi Book Centre of Mumbai and Gandhi Research Foundation of Jalgaon archives a shred of oral history in the form of a conversation between Gandhi and Bose that took place in November 1934 and published in *The Hindustan Times* on 17 October 1935.[13]

This, I believe, is more than anecdotal. Researchers in India know only too well about the non-compliance of publishers with the depository law enjoining them to submit a copy of all publications with four designated libraries including the NLI. A few state governments have attempted to tighten rules of legal deposit in their remit, but the Union government has failed to update the law. A draft revision to the Delivery of Books and Newspapers (Public Libraries) Act 1954, amended in 1957 (DB Act),[14] was prepared after a stakeholders' meeting at the NLI on 25 March 2011, but no amendment has been passed since. Apart from the derisory financial penalties in the DB Act that publishers ignore with impunity, born-digital materials are not covered by the Act. Even many government reports, such as census data are on occasions unavailable in the designated libraries because these are published electronically (although a few are freely available online). At the same time, the government has wasted no time in amending the Press and Registration of Books Act (PRB Act) of 1867, passed by the British to control Indian publications after the Great Indian Rebellion of 1857. Several amendments were made between 1870 and 1983. A new Bill was tabled in 2011, but the Standing Parliamentary Committee

to which it was referred had reservations. When I inquired last, the government headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi had tried to push through a new revision in 2017, although the Bill lapsed with the closure of Parliament in May 2019.[15] Successive governments did not display equal alacrity in updating the DB Act or in curbing the menace of paid and fake news. Even then, the PRB Act was more potent than the DB Act. Enforcing the DB Act was a forlorn task for the Director General of the NLI, and I sought solace in the wisdom that it made sense for the publisher to be more wary of the Director General of the State Police who took custody of deposits under the PRB Act.

What are the implications of such matters for archival resources for the history of post-Independence India? Government indifference to amending the laws affects accessibility and service in official archives and depositories. Many ministries and departments of the Union government, as Guha has noted, do not send non-current papers to the NAI. I may add that they, together with the state governments, do not deposit gazettes and other important reports with the NLI, and the ones that are dispatched at times lie unsorted in the Indian Official Documents (IOD) Division of the short-staffed library. The laxity that is alleged against commercial publishers when speaking of the DB Act is equally true of government ministries and departments. The slackness with records is less a result of national traits such as carelessness and paranoia than the inability to pace legislation with technology and upgrade political understanding as much as professional training. When I joined the NLI in 2010 laptop computers were not permitted, putting off most users, since the library was a 'Subordinate Office' of the Union Ministry of Culture. Hence, laptops were considered a security threat. I was able to change all that in the first few weeks of my term with the help of a learned and combative bureaucrat who looked after the Ministry. At the same time, I had to trump objecting staff by calling in the local police sans their uniform to demonstrate that the hand-held scanners the objectors trusted were mostly dud equipment and that an embarrassing number of fire extinguishers were 'security risks' since these were long past the date for hydrostatic pressure tests.

Safety measures have improved since then, but knowledge of resources, as the episode concerning the Bose diaries shows, has not. The stagnation means that many records in private hands, even if they ought to be treated as 'public' records as Guha writes, do not reach government archives. Donors choose special libraries, especially academic institutions, for bequeathing these documents, and the travelling researcher, always pressed for time, does not have access to a consolidated collection. Indian official archives are silent not simply because they are forced into silence by political regimes and by uncaring or paranoid guardians of the papers, but also because the records trail off at clefts created by shoddy collection management by overworked and ill-trained staff.

In short, records do not suffer neglect and damage in India because of some flawed national trait like a bad diet: the systemic faults that limit archival materials for writing contemporary history cannot be laid at the door of an imagined cultural habit. I would tend to agree with Michael Moss and David Thomas, although

not perhaps exactly in the sense in which they employ the chiasmus, when they write in Chapter 1 that the supposed absence of evidence in the archives is not necessarily evidence of absence.[16] A great number of citizens are aware of the value of materials in their custody, but prefer to hand them over to non-governmental archives. However, many of the institutions that receive archival gifts do not have the wherewithal to preserve old papers, and are at any rate more interested in making or procuring digital copies. Like the families that relinquish them, the institutions look for better funded organizations when they feel no longer capable of maintaining the material records. When the papers do finally reach institutions such as the NAI or the NLI, they are already in an advanced stage of disrepair. What makes the situation worse is that in-house use of hybrid cameras capable of simultaneous digitizing and microfilming of documents is rare outside large government collections. Accustomed to the low priority accorded to microfilming and armed with the conviction that digitization will salvage the remains, the staff at donee institutions submit the material substrate of the documents to further damage, and the ruined bequest takes with it centuries of the history of the written word or the visual image.

The lack of interest in empirical research on contemporary history in India, in my non-specialist view, owes less to the lure of high theory and paucity of archival sources than to the way archival resources are treated, processed and disseminated. Are Indians genuinely uncaring about records? Partly perhaps. In 2014, I had occasion to serve on a small committee constituted to reorganize the archival holdings of Visvabharati Granthana Vibhaga Library, the publication wing of Visvabharati, the university in Santiniketan founded by the poet Rabindranath Tagore.[17] Rabindra Bhavana in Santiniketan, which houses the university museum and archives, has priceless treasures, many of them unexplored and unprinted, such as the diaries of Tagore's elder brother Jyotirindranath Tagore, playwright, translator from the Sanskrit and French, skilled painter and composer – unquestionably the most versatile of the remarkable Tagore family except for Rabindranath himself. But the letters and documents relating to the press and publishing wing founded by Tagore have all but disappeared. There were several items of value, but I looked in vain for correspondence with authors and booksellers, old issue registers of titles borrowed from the office in Kolkata, and detailed account books that would have been a book historian's delight, not to speak of that of the historian studying twentieth-century history since Visvabharati Granthana Vibhaga continues to publish important titles, not necessarily Tagore and Tagoreana.

Yet there seems to be a different side to the story. There is no dearth of scholars and projects in India keen on building archives of resources for a history of the recent past – a rare few without any funding or minimal institutional support. Ashoka University, one of the leading new private institutions near Delhi, is putting together a promising archive named Ashoka Archives of Contemporary India. In Kolkata, the place I know best, there are scores of archives that house materials for a historian of contemporary India. The major ones such as the relevant Divisions in the NLI – IOD, Newspaper Stack and Reading Room, Rare Books, Maps, and

Gift and Exchange – are well known. The NLI houses such treasures as the Gandhi-Sapru correspondence, the letters of Subhas Chandra Bose to his nephew, the papers of the historian Jadunath Sarkar including his correspondence with his colleague G.S. Sardesai, and the manuscripts of the Bengali poet Jibanananda Das and Bishnu Dey.[18] The capital of British India moved to Delhi from Kolkata in 1911, but the West Bengal State Archives still have rare materials for recent Indian history, as I discovered when compiling the institutional digital archive of Presidency University on the occasion of its bicentenary in 2017.[19] Speaking of Presidency, there are other academic institutions with specialized archives such as those of the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) in Kolkata, founded by Prasanta Chandra Mahalanobis (1893–1972), a younger associate of Tagore, physicist and statistician responsible for formulating what is now known as 'Mahalanobis Distance'. He started a small Statistical Laboratory at Presidency University (then College), which grew into a world-class teaching and research facility with branches across the country. Nehru, who generously supported Mahalanobis, entrusted him with a key role in the economic planning of free India. The digital archives at the School of Cultural Texts and Records at Jadavpur University has an outstanding collection of modern literary manuscripts, street literature, film scripts, political ephemera, personal correspondence, newspaper clippings and music, while Calcutta University has archived its institutional records and rare holdings.[20] Other institutions such as Sanskrit College and University, Alia University (earlier Calcutta Madrasah or Madrasah Alia) and St Xavier's College have important collections that may not be of much use to the historian of contemporary India, but they testify to Indians' enthusiasm for building and managing archives with modest resources. The Union Ministry of Culture funds a few smaller archives in the city that have resources relating to recent history such as the Asiatic Society, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad Institute of Asian Studies, Netaji Research Bureau, the archive of the Centre for Studies in Social Sciences Calcutta (CSSSC) and the allied Jadunath Bhavan Museum and Research Centre (JBMRC).[21] Not all of these are managed well, but their collections keep growing. Bequests and voluntary service support the archives of autonomous organisations, a few of which receive minimal or scant governmental support. The Bangiya Sahitya Parishat, founded as the Bengal Academy of Letters in 1893, has over 9000 rare manuscripts in several languages, many of them apparently unrelated to modern India, although it continues to receive gifts from families of more recent writers.[22] One could go on adding to the list, and I was only speaking of archives in Kolkata. One has not even begun counting the archives of feudatory princedoms (vassal states ruled by Indian princes),[23] political parties, religious sects, caste-based organizations, basic sciences, technology, medicine, music, cinema and other audio-visual media, media houses and the countless smaller collections in the remoter districts. Busy scholars find it difficult to access materials in these smaller under-funded archives in Bengal and elsewhere. Opening hours are restricted because of scant staff, and reprographic facilities for documents that will withstand reproduction are archaic. While these frustrate researchers, they may take heart from the number of people, across classes and age-groups, who are willing to offer voluntary service and generous gifts to local public libraries with

small but interesting archives. Kolkata even has an archive of little magazines named Kolkata Little Magazine Library and Research Centre. Little magazines in Bengal (not necessarily in the Bengali language) play a composite role of *avant garde* literary periodicals, learned journals and serious reviews. The Centre was put together by Sandip Dutta. Appalled by the NLI's neglect of Bengali little magazines, he started his own collection in 1978, and the stock has now swelled to over 60,000 volumes. Dutta maintains a piggy bank named the 'The Three Penny Opera' to fund his two-roomed library containing rare gems. The library is open to public membership, and celebrity writers and scholars work in the cramped space between book-lined walls in Dutta's ancestral home. The Centre received a small grant in 2006–2007 to digitize part of its holdings.[24] Finally, Bichitra Pathshala and JBMRC in Kolkata launched a project titled 'Magic of My School' in January 2019. Students search for historically significant records and memorabilia in their schools under the project, and a few would eventually lead to the creation of their own archives and museums. At the time of writing, at least 25 schools were part of the project.[25]

I hence find myself only in partial agreement with Guha's observation on the carelessness and paranoia of Indians about documents of potential archival value. Compare the cavalier attitude of custodians of government archives and holders of 'private' papers of relevance to that of archivists of a different breed livening up the archival scene in India today, admittedly after Guha had written his piece for *EPW*, but certainly prior to his 2016 lecture. If silence in the archives speak of political suppression or lack of care and consolidation, there is also an unmistakable buzz that digital technology has enabled. Take the instances of crowd-sourced archives such as the Indian Memory Project (IMP).[26] Started in 2010 by Anusha Yadav, the IMP is a visual and narrative archive of life in the Indian sub-continent through personal archives of photographs and letters punctuated with recalled memories. Only pre-1992 items find a place since the founder felt that people seemed to have more objective memories of times not too recent. Two other projects drawing attention are the Citizens Archive of India (CAI) and the Partition Archive. The CAI, launched by Rohan Parikh in 2016, is a collection of projects recording memories and materials of Indians born before 1947.[27] We learn from a report in *The Hindustan Times* last updated on 10 January 2020 that the site then had over 375 hours of interviews, more than 1300 items such as letters, documents, newspapers and photographs, and the numbers were rising steadily.[28] The 1947 Partition Archive was started by Guneeta Singh Bhalla in 2011. It documents stories and visual evidence of over 9500 oral stories recorded in 12 countries in 36 languages.[29] Bhalla left her job the following year, and started managing the archive full-time from her base in University of California at Berkeley.[30] One gets a sense of undivided India, more sectarian perhaps than post-Partition imagination tends to paint it as. Nevertheless, India certainly appears to have been less prone to submit to the bullying of short-sighted, mean and self-appointed guardians of religious and caste groups who to various extents have influenced later regimes in the sub-continent.

These crowd-sourced archives of the recent past are usually passion projects, and partly depend – 'partly' since letters, documents, photographs and other non-oral

texts are part of the archives – on the uses of oral history. Such archives as the 1947 Partition Archive have the power to bring together estranged families and cultures, to reconfigure identities, to impel dispersed or diasporic histories toward a possible convergence. Not all archives are intended to reconcile: many are designed to remember and bear witness to horrors such as the Holocaust or the 1971 genocide in Bangladesh.[31] Yet, as IMP, CAI and the Partition Archive show, non-formal crowd-sourced archives may serve a cultural and anthropological purpose more than one that is 'historical' in the strict sense. Past memories hurt, present verbalization, even oral formulation, heals. At the same time, visual records create a palimpsest of the historical times we simultaneously inhabit, just as the night sky shining with light from distant light-years makes us inhabitants of a singular yet wildly discrepant spacetime. Archives such as @soaspostcard: Early Postcards from India may have been designed to historically place and document locations and objects, but these begin to acquire shades of a paradox.[32] The clothes we wear, the food we eat and the cars we drive, often at the same point time in the same or different geographical spaces, seem culturally abrupt and discontinuous –similar to the sense of discontinuity we experience when we revisit a town we once knew well. In the most unexpected way, it resists the sense of historical causation and continuity, and people's histories seem inhospitable to a history of the people.

The keenness of citizens to promote and participate in such Indian projects as the CAI sort oddly with the systemic lacunae and unforced negligence one faces in government archives. Crowd-sourced non-formal archives have admitted gaps in written and audio-visual documentation; memories are fallible, and oral histories subjective. But, then, official archival records and surveys are skewed to suit a regime's priorities; reliable histories of neither the colonial nor the recent past are fortified by resources that are closed to access and subject to censorship.

But a deeper question troubles the use of crowd-sourced, non-formal and principally oral archives: are these so-called 'people's histories' add up to a 'history of the people'? Even if we abandon hope of a pattern, we need to parse the documents and oral histories in these archives, just as much as the records in official archives. However, the two tasks call for different hermeneutic protocols, a fact imperfectly realized at times by historians who call for a judicious blend of oral narratives with official and personal written papers. The tasks are distinct, although they may be made to serve complementary functions. Take the Partition of India, for instance. Urvashi Butalia's (2000) book on the Partition, which makes liberal use of oral history alongside the discipline's more familiar bases of information, may be deemed a good example of not simply a judicious selection, but also an understanding of hybrid sources.[33]

Yet two questions haunt the easy counsel of judicious handling of oral resources, and both questions involve the attempt to find meaning in historical events. The first question is, who determines meaning? If the analytical tools of the oral historian are different, is she complicit, like the political arbiters and censors behind the archival policy of the government, in imposing a pattern on the resources at her disposal? 'An archive presupposes an archivist,' writes Arlette Farge in her book on the traditional archive published in French in 1989, 'a hand that collects and

classifies.' And further, 'we know that for a document to take on meaning it must be questioned pointedly'.[34] With oral history, the interviewer is collector, classifier and interrogator of the text. The text provide answers to only those questions that we ask from our vantage in time.[35] The second question concerns the analytical devices themselves. The tools designed to tease out meaning from oral or non-formal written and visual materials are themselves subject to what the historian perceives as a system. Do oral archives add to the Hegelian enterprise that subsumes history into a philosophical system?

In the interest of brevity, I shall restrict myself to oral history. In 1986, the International Council of Archives produced a set of guidelines for archivists on oral materials under UNESCO's Records and Archives Management Programme (RAMP), General Information Programme and United Nations International Scientific Information System (UNISIST).[36] Dated it may well be, but the study remains useful, especially for questions raised by recent non-formal and crowd-sourced archives. The RAMP study makes a distinction between transactional records such as constitutions, laws, deeds, treaties, licences, patents, proclamations, contracts, orders and advertisements that are produced for conducting the business of an organization. These constitute primary evidence for the historian and are different from concurrent descriptions such as audio or video recordings and stenographic notes that serve as aids to memory and are termed selective records. Limited by the technology of the recording devices, such records are necessarily 'selective' and demand an interpretive layer. The terms seem innocent and clear. Yet transactional records can be selective too, and hence compromise on their value as evidence. Consider the following passage:

> Recordings of oral history interviews and oral tradition narrations are therefore selective records of those events. Selective records are highly valued as historical evidence for their contemporary character, but their evidential value must always be somewhat less than that of transactional records.

At the same time, selective records are 'primary evidence of what someone decided to record or was capable of recording'.[37] The question is who wished to record and why. If the government orders the recording of a presentation or programme, or if an organization presents such recordings including interviews to secure a grant or a licence, they, for the historian at least, share features of a transaction despite the demonstrable concurrence. In fact, the concurrence on such occasions confer on the records the ontological features of a transaction, with the expectation that these would be treated as primary evidence.

Nothing is ever gained by unwarranted hair-splitting. I bring this up merely to stress that making distinctions among forms of evidence becomes so difficult that it is at times given up as the wrong thing to do. Among selective records are recollections. The authors of the RAMP study admit that if human memory is selective, recollections select from selections. They speak of three levels of evidence: the event, the memory of the event which is selective, and the selective account

of the witness who recollects and narrates. The fourth level involves the questions selected by the interviewer and her purpose, which trigger the memories called up in the interviewee.[38] In other words, although this is not how the authors describe it, recollections are as *analytic* as they are reconstructions: respondents need to piece together memories after analysing, whether self-consciously or not, the direction and purpose of both the inquiry and testament. Memory, as much as recollection, is an interpretive production – rooted in the present and in present considerations of a desired future. Perhaps this has led some to call archives 'memories of the future'.[39]

The vertiginous climb up the ladder of evidential authenticity such as we find in the RAMP study bothers archivists less these days. Oral history theory at present almost uniformly insists that the purposes and analytic tools of oral history are different from those of written history and indeed from those of 'History' as a discipline. We derive anthropological and sociological insights into emotions and their memory: what we are looking at is a history of subjectivity judged as a species of cultural performance.[40] Oral records, in this view, are far from self-evident: like dreams and associative metaphors, they present the analyst with a hermeneutic task not directed at supplementing the 'primary' evidence of archaeology and written documents.

However, it seems that India can ill afford to ignore oral and non-formal archives in its pursuit of a theoretically sound history of post-Independence years. A country with an average literacy rate of 77.7 per cent, that is, with an illiterate population of around 307 million, would find it a philosophical luxury to be finicky with oral records.[41] The 'national' community in India was not imagined into birth by print in the colonial era. Peasant India had erupted in revolt in the name of a 'national' and self-ruled community – although indicated by Indian terms such as *jati*, which may collide with the sense of caste – long before the Western idea of the nation-state fuelled the freedom struggle.[42] The oral in India belongs to a category of phenomena that demands admissibility as historical evidence.

The way out, as I see it, is to treat oral and non-formal archives as resources for the history of post-Independence India like diversifications of a meaningful history that may be treated like a Leibnizian monadic substrate. The monad needs to be dynamic.[43] Shorn of dynamism, the material substrate – written or oral – becomes dead, hermeneutically sterile, incapable of endogenous growth and variation. Subjectivity represents the static substrate; individuality, its diversified variant. Without the possibility of diversification of the substance, there is no logic to history. The alternative is history that gives us a disparate series of contingent events, a dead chronicle that we report like coroners at an autopsy. Even as we concede that the species of archives – governmental, institutional, written, oral, crowd-sourced – we are dealing with are different, one has to reclaim history's disciplinary potency of deriving meaning from new archives that are otherwise born dead.

Notes

1 Express News Service, 'Major Gaps Exist in Historical Understanding of Post-Independence India: Ramachandra Guha', *The Indian Express*, 20 January 2016 https://

indianexpress.com/article/cities/mumbai/major-gaps-exist-in-historical-understanding-of-post-independence-india-ramachandra-guha/, read on 9 June 2020.

2 See www.godrej.com, read on 9 June 2020.

3 See www.archives.godrej.com/activities.html, read on 9 June 2020.

4 Ramachandra Guha, 'The Challenge of Contemporary History', *Economic and Political Weekly* (*EPW*), 43, no. 26–7 (28 June 2008), 192–200.

5 See Nivedita Menon, 'The Historian and "His"Others: A Response to Ramachandra Guha', *EPW*, 43, no. 40 (4 October 2008), 73–76; Nonica Datta, 'A "Samvad" with Ramachandra Guha', *EPW*, 43, no. 40 (4 October 2008), 81–83; Sasheej Hegde, 'The Demands of Contemporary History: A Comment', *EPW*, 43, no. 40 (4 October 2008), 77–80.

6 See Leon Festinger, *A Theory of Cognitive Dissonance* (Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press, 1957).

7 The reservations were voiced by D. Subbarao, who was then Governor of the Reserve Bank of India. See C.R.L. Narasimhan, 'Official Statistics Need to be Reliable', *The Hindu*, 10 July 2011, Updated 18 October 2016; www.thehindu.com/business/Economy/Official-statistics-need-to-be-reliable/article13738415.ece, read on 20 July 2020. For a more technical and recent comment on the subject see, Arvind Subramanian and Josh Felman, 'India's Great Slowdown: What Happened? What's the Way Out?', CID Faculty Working Paper No. 370 (December 2019), Centre for International Development at Harvard University, pp. 32–34.

8 See www.dgciskol.gov.in/Writereaddata/Downloads/Data_dissemination_policy1.pdf, read on 20 July 2020.

9 Nirmal Kumar Basu (Nirmal Kumar Bose), *Satchallisher diary* [Personal Diary and Pocket Diary of Nirmal Kumar Basu, 1947] (Kolkata: Punshcha, 1990).

10 See www.indiaculture.nic.in/gandhian-heritage, read on 15 April 2020.

11 I spoke to Mr Virat Kothari at an international workshop titled 'Knowledge Engineering for Digital Library Design' organized by the National Digital Library of India in collaboration with UNESCO at the UNESCO House, New Delhi, from 25 to 27 October 2017. For the Gandhi Heritage Portal, see www.gandhiheritageportal.org/ read on 26 October 2017.

12 See www.gandhiheritageportal.org/fundamental-worklist, read on 14 September 2020.

13 See www.mkgandhi.org/articles/gandhis-interview-with-nirmal-kumar-bose.html, read on 14 September 2020.

14 See *The Delivery of Books and Newspapers (Public Libraries) Act, 1954*, http://legislative.gov.in/sites/default/files/A1954-27_1.pdf, last read on 14 September 2020. Other attempts were made to amend the Act before and after the stakeholders' meeting at the NLI. See, for instance, Bill No. 44 of 2008 http://164.100.47.4/billstexts/lsbilltexts/asintroduced/2332ls-02.pdf, read on 14 September 2020.

15 See Gaurav Vivek Bhatnagar, 'Modi Government's Draft Press Registration Bill May Restrict Digital Media's Freedom', *The Wire*, 27 November 2019, https://thewire.in/media/centre-media-freedom-press-bill, read on 14 September 2020.

16 See Michael Moss and David Thomas, 'Theorising the Silences', Chapter 1, p. 11.

17 The other members on the Committee were Dr V. K. Thomas, University Librarian, Visvabharati, and Ramkumar Mukhopadhyay, the novelist who was then Director, Visvabharati Granthana Vibhaga. See www.facebook.com/vbgvlibrary/, read on 14 September 2020.

18 It is hard to offer even the roughest estimate of these documents' value, and they are not even a minute fraction of the materials at the NLI. Tej Bahadur Sapru (1875–1949) led the Indian Liberal Party and made common cause with Gandhi's Non-Cooperation Movement (1920–2). He called an All Party Conference to begin work on the Indian Constitution in 1927, and helped draft the Nehru Committee Report on Constitutional Reforms the following year. Jadunath Sarkar (1870–1958) was one of the leading historians from Bengal who was made member of the Indian Historical Records Commission

(IHRC) when it was founded in 1919. He helped shape archival policies before and after independence, as did the Marathi historian G.S. Sardesai (1865–1959). They used archival records outside those of the Imperial Record Department (IRD: the institution that was turned into NAI after Independence), obtained permission from the IHRC in 1930 to access the Peshwa's archives. Sardesai edited 45 volumes of *Selections from Peshwa's Daftar* (1930–4) and with Sarkar compiled 11 volumes of *Poona Residency Records*. See Dipesh Chakrabarty, *The Calling of History: Sir Jadunath Sarkar and His Empire of Truth* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2015), *passim*, and Sabyasachi Bhattacharya, *Archiving the British Raj: History of the Archival Policy of the Government of India, with Selected Documents, 1858–1947* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2019), pp. 126–127, 180. Jibanananda Das (1899–1954) is held by many in India and Bangladesh to have been the most important Bengali poet after Tagore, and Bishnu Dey (1909–1982) was a Marxist poet and thinker who, although radically different in temperament from Das, was along with him a major architect of high modernism in Bengali literature.

19 See www.presiuniv.ndl.iitkgp.ac.in/xmlui/, read on 18 September 2020. This collection contains important sources for the history of education in India before and after 1947.

20 See www.isical.ac.in/~museum/, read on 14 September 2020, for the Prasanta Chandra Mahalanobis Memorial Museum and Archives, which preserves Mahalanobis's personal, scientific and official papers. For the digital collections at the School of Cultural Texts and Records of Jadavpur University and at Calcutta University, see respectively www.jaduniv.edu.in/view_department.php?deptid = 135 and www.culibrary.ac.in, read on 14 September 2020.

21 The private collection of papers of the freedom fighter and free India's first Education Minister Maulana Abul Kalam Azad is now housed in the museum of the Institute of Asian Studies in Kolkata named after him. The papers have been digitized by the School of Cultural Texts and Records of Jadavpur University. See https://granthsouthasia.wordpress.com/makaias-pilot-study-collection/, read on 14 September 2020. The Asiatic Society, founded in 1784 by Sir William Jones, is one of the first modern (that is, 'modern' in the Western sense) research institutions in Asia. Its focus has always been 'Asiatick Researches' in all branches of learning, and many institutions including the Indian Museum in Kolkata were derived from its collections. The Society encourages research in the history of modern scientific institutions such as the Indian Institute of Science and the Indian Institute of Technology, the culture and history of indigenous peoples currently inhabiting India, the recent history of insurgent groups in north-eastern India, and continuing Asian oral traditions. See www.asiaticsocietykolkata.org/, read on 15 September 2020. Netaji Research Bureau in Kolkata is located in the family home of Subhas Chandra Bose (1897–1945) in Kolkata. Bose (also known as 'Netaji' or Esteemed Leader) was a nationalist who broke ranks with the Indian National Congress and led the Indian National Army, formed in south-east Asia from British-Indian soldiers taken prisoner by Japan in the Malayan campaign. Bose marched his troops to the Indian border through Myanmar with the help of Axis powers during the Second World War with the aim of liberating India. The museum at the Bureau holds important papers and visual materials related to India's freedom struggle, and there is an updated archive containing textual and audio-visual materials relating to post-Independence India and the war of liberation in Bangladesh. See https://netaji.org/museum.html and https://netaji.org/nrb-archives.html, read on 14 September 2020.

22 Bangiya Sahitya Parishat, which has a fine collection of medieval Bengali manuscripts and printed books, has recently acquired the house, personal library and memorabilia of the leading Bengali novelist and one-time Congress activist Tarasankar Bandyopadhyay (1898–1971). Other bequests keep trickling in from modern writers, including living ones. See https://bangiyasahityaparishat.org/, read on 14 September 2020.

23 West Bengal had one important princedom in the colonial period – Coochbehar, although major areas of the native state of Tripura were geographically part of undivided Bengal. Segments of the former princedom are now in Bangladesh, and Tripura

is a separate state in the Indian Union. There are rich archives in the vassal states such as those of Cochin stretching up to 1949, now merged with the State Archives of Kerala, and in colonies under European powers other than Britain, such as the archive in the Archdiocese of Goa, a Portuguese colony thatbecame independent only after an Indian invasion in 1961.

24 See https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kolkata_Little_Magazine_Library_And_Research_Center, read on 15 September 2020. The grant made by the India Foundation for the Arts amounted to around 500,000 Indian rupees (a fraction below 7000 US dollars). The digitization was done by CSSSC of which the JBMRC is part, and a digital copy of the volumes digitized was acquired by the CSSSC archive. See http://indiaifa.org/kalikata-little-magazine-library-o-gabeshona-kendra.html, read on 15 September 2020.

25 See Subha Das Mollick, 'Students and Teachers of 25 Schools in Kolkata Embark on a Journey to Explore the History of their Schools', https://intheedition.wordpress.com/2019/05/17/schools-gear-up-to-create-magic/, read on 18 September 2020. The Oriental Seminary, a Kolkata school that started life in 1829, already has an archive named after its founder – Gourmohan Auddy Memorial Archive. So have a few of the older schools in town such as La Martiniere for Boys, established in 1836.

26 See www.indianmemoryproject.com/, read on 20 September 2020.

27 See https://citizensarchiveofindia.org/, read on 20 September 2020.

28 See Danish Raza, 'How Crowdsourced Archives are Making Indian History Personal and Accessible', *The Hindustan Times*, 10 January 2020 www.hindustantimes.com/art-and-culture/how-digital-archives-are-making-indian-history-personal-and-accessible/story-EbmGpGfKFAY4G4Z8BmY7OJ.html, read on 20 September 2020.

29 See https://in.1947partitionarchive.org/, read on 20 September 2020.

30 'Murder, Rape and Shattered Families: 1947 Partition Archive Effort Under Way', *Dawn*, 13 March 2015 www.dawn.com/news/1169309, read on 20 September 2020. The archive was in the news during the pandemic as speakers from both sides of the border between India and Pakistan joined online to share their experiences; see Payel Mohta, 'The Coronavirus Pandemic Gave 1947 Partition Archive an Unlikely Shot in the Arm—A Series with Speakers from Both Sides of the Border', *Firstpost*, 21 July 2020 www.firstpost.com/art-and-culture/by-going-digital-1947-partition-archive-is-able-to-reach-more-people-feature-cross-border-experts-in-a-new-talk-series-8,611,841.html, read on 20 September 2020.

31 See the Holocaust Collection, US National Archives, Records on Fold 3. See https://go.fold3.com/holocaust_records, read on 20 September 2020. See also the educational resource offered by the National Archives of the United Kingdom www.nationalarchives.gov.uk/education/resources/holocaust/, read on 20 September 2020. Two relevant archives on the Bangladesh genocide are Bangladesh Genocide Archivewww.genocidebangladesh.org/, and Muktijuddho e-Archive www.liberationwarbangladesh.org, read on 20 September 2020.

32 The archive is curated by Emily Stevenson and Richard Hughes of the Department of Anthropology, School of Oriental and African Studies, University of London. See www.picuki.com/tag/soaspostcard, read on 20 September 2020.

33 Urvashi Butalia, *The Other Side of Silence: Voices from the Partition of India* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2000).

34 Arlette Farge, *The Allure of the Archives*, trans. Thomas Scott-Railton (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013), pp. 3, 14.

35 See Hans-Georg Gadamer, *Philosophical Hermeneutics*, trans. and ed. David E. Linge (Berkeley, CA: University of California Press, 1976), pp. 100–101.

36 William Moss and Peter C. Mazikana, *Archives, Oral History and Oral Tradition: A RAMP Study* (Paris: UNESCO General Information Programme and United Nations International Scientific Information System, 1986).

37 Ibid., p. 6.

38 Ibid., pp. 7–8.

39 Gary Taylor, 'Memories of the Future', *Cultural Selection: Why Some Achievements Survive the Test of Time—and Others Don't* (New York: Basic Books, 1996), pp. 237–254. A three-month long photographic exhibition titled 'The Memory of the Future' opened in Musée de l'Elysée on 25 May 2016 www.elysee.ch/en/exhibitions-and-events/expositions/the-memory-of-the-future/, read on 20 September 2020. The phrase has been used many times before and after, in titles of exhibitions, essays and at least one novel (Siri Hustvedt, *Memories of the Future*, New York: Simon and Schuster, 2019).
40 For an overview, see Lynn Abrams, *Oral History Theory* (New York: Routledge, 2010).
41 This is the figure of 2017 released by the National Statistical Office. See 'NSO Report Shows Stark Digital Divide Affects Education', *The Hindu*, 8 September 2020 www.thehindu.com/news/national/nso-report-shows-stark-digital-divide-affects-education/article32554222.ece, read on 20 September 2020.
42 This was pointed out by Ranajit Guha in a review of Benedict Anderson's book *Imagined Communities: Reflections on the Origin and Spread of Nationalism* (1983; revised and enlarged edition, London: Verso, 1991); see Ranajit Guha, 'Nationalism Reduced to Official Nationalism', *Asian Studies Review*, 9 (1985), 103–108.
43 See Alain Renaut, *The Era of the Individual: A Contribution to the History of Subjectivity*, trans. M.B. DeBevoise and Franklin Philip (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1997; Indian edition, Delhi: Motilal Banarasidass, 2000), pp. 118–121.

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